

other way, towards the JD(U)-BJP alliance. In 2019, the combined National Democratic Alliance had cornered 54 per cent of the vote share and 39 of Bihar's 40 seats. With Nitish now back in the fold, the BJP hopes to retain that showing, counting on the support of the dominant castes, the non-Yadav OBCs, Most Backward Classes (a social grouping that makes up a fourth of Bihar's population and over whom Nitish retains a significant grip), the Paswans, Musahars and other Dalit communities. The presence of Jitan Ram Manjhi's Hindustani Awami Morcha (Secular), Chirag Paswan's Lok Janshakti Party and Upendra Kushwaha's Rashtriya Lok Janata Dal only bolster that cause.

The BJP, as always, is leaving nothing to chance even with Nitish on its side. It continues to pander to caste arithmetic, as was evident in its choice of the two deputy chief ministers—Samrat Choudhury and Vijay Sinha. Choudhury, a Kushwaha (also known as Koeri), is expected to arrest the decline of Luv-Kush (Kurmi-Koeri) support for Nitish. Kushwahas form 6 per cent of the electorate. The deputy CM's post is the second highest constitutional position a Kushwaha has occupied since Satish Prasad Singh's five-day stint as CM in 1968. The appointment of Sinha, a Bhumihar, is intended to placate the dominant castes, who form 16 per cent of the state's population and are the core vote base of the BJP. Besides these calculated moves, the BJP is making enough symbolic gestures to reach out to the larger OBC vote bank and evoke collective Bihari pride. Honouring former Bihar CM Karpoori Thakur, a backward caste icon, with the Bharat Ratna was one such move.

I.N.D.I.A. HAD PINNED ITS HOPES ON THE CASTE CARD TO TAKE ON THE BJP, BUT THE GAINS OF NITISH'S CASTE SURVEY WILL NOW ACCRUE TO JD(U)-BJP

All this has robbed the Opposition alliance the chance of making it a clear-cut backwards vs dominant caste battle in Bihar, as its support base gets reduced to the Muslim-Yadav combination, which makes up a third of the state's voters. If there is one thing the RJD can take heart from, it's that its core vote base never deserted Lalu despite the series of electoral, political and legal reverses. Even in its worst performance in 2019, when the party failed to win even one of the 20 Lok Sabha seats it contested, the RJD polled 16 per cent votes. The Opposition alliance also holds significant sway among a section of politicised Dalit voters, thanks to the CPI(ML).

However, retaining the core vote base at the regional level is of little consolation when the caste census plank seems unlikely to find the national resonance necessary to win electoral dividends for I.N.D.I.A. The limitations of the plank stood exposed in the recent assembly elections in three heartland states that have a significant OBC population—Madhya Pradesh, Rajasthan and Chhattisgarh—where the Congress promised a caste census if voted to power but lost in all three states. Meanwhile, even as its larger Hindutva campaign continues apace, the BJP assiduously nurtures various social blocs, whether by celebrating their icons or by giving community members important political posts. It has also cleverly crafted a whole vote bank outside of caste, comprising people who are the beneficiaries of the various welfare schemes of the government—what is now classified as the *labharthi varg*.

That said, caste consideration is not going away anytime soon. It has received fresh impetus in Maharashtra, where Chief Minister Eknath Shinde has acceded to the Maratha demand for reservation, which could compli-